



2nd Gen Echo Buds

A set of leaks from an Anker listing hints at 2nd Gen Echo Buds with wireless charging. <http://digit.in/nov20-65>



Harley-Davidson electric bicycle

The company's first foray into the ebike market - Serial 1, is set to be available in March 2021. <http://digit.in/nov20-66>

ASUS ROG Cetra

Tailor-made for gamers

After the immense popularisation of wireless headsets, wired ones have sort of become the anomaly. However, most gamers, especially at competitive levels, prefer their latency-free wired counterparts even today. To that end, Taiwanese company ASUS recently launched an in-ear wired pair of gaming headphones that are primarily geared towards gamers. These are the ASUS ROG Cetra gaming earphones. Let's find out how it fares in our review.

Build and comfort

The ASUS ROG Cetra in-ear headphones are designed stylistically to match the gamer aesthetic. The earphones are primarily black in colour with the outer casings of the earbuds that house the ROG logo lighting up red when they are plugged into the source device. Speaking of the source device, the earphones draw power from the connected device that powers the ANC functionality and the lights.

The earbuds feature a rather conventional design with an angled nozzle and silicone buds at the end to aid fit and comfort. However, they do come with silicone wings or fins to further enhance the fit. ASUS has packed three sizes of silicone ear tips (S, M, L) and an extra pair of memory-foam tips, which were, by far, our favourite. The earbuds are comfortable, ergonomic, and fit most ears given the number of ear tips options provided.

The cable length is 1.25 metres, however, it isn't braided or nylon, which is disappointing. The in-line module features controls for Active Noise Cancellation, Ambient mode, playback, volume, and calls. There's also a microphone higher up on the cable.

At the other end, the earphones have a USB Type-C connector that isn't angled. Overall, the earphones scream gaming aesthetically and are sufficiently well-built but the buttons



on the in-line remote are slightly hard-to-press.

Features

Two of the biggest headlining features the ASUS ROG Cetra employs are Active Noise Cancellation and Ambient Sound mode. The ANC is enough to drown out some distractions such as the AC drone, PC hum, and more, but struggles with low-mid to mid-range sounds, and highs are obviously not suppressed. Ambient Sound, on the other hand, works pretty well and amplifies background sounds significantly to a point where you can hear them even if there's music playing at about 40-50 per cent volume.

Now, if you are using the ROG Cetra with your laptop or PC, you can install the Armoury II software that offers additional controls and customisations. The software comes equipped with an adjustable EQ, bit rate and frequency response controls, sound presets, and a Virtual Surround Sound toggle. You can create different kinds of profiles for different games and apply them when necessary. The software isn't available in app form for mobile phones.

Performance: Gaming and Music

Featuring 10.8mm dynamic driver, the ASUS ROG Cetra sounds like they're especially tuned for gaming. The earphones feature excellent staging

and separation that make games such as Call of Duty: Mobile sound positionally-accurate, and dynamic. The wide soundstage allows for accurate positioning of gunshots and footsteps and the emphasised treble response makes gunshots sound lively and dynamic. In other games such as Asphalt 9 that have a prominent background score, the ROG Cetra weren't as impressive, but slightly better than standard wired earphones. The omnidirectional microphone is pretty competent and work well for games such as Among Us that require you to talk on Discord. The microphone picked up our voice and relayed it sufficiently well, with minimal distortion.



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Coming to music, the ASUS ROG Cetra are out of their element here. The sound signature is overly bright with subdued lows and bass, and tinny highs.

Bottomline

The ASUS ROG Cetra are designed, stylistically and sound-wise, for gamers. They feature premium features as well as multi-platform compatibility. The sound quality for gaming is commendable with stellar staging and emphasised highs that make for directionally-accurate and lively gunshots in FPS games. The earphones are also pretty good for other games such as Among Us owing to the solid omnidirectional microphone performance. Overall, for ₹7,699, the earphones are pricey but if you value excellent positional cues in gaming and a gamer aesthetic, the ROG Cetra may be the right choice for you.

—Dhriti Datta

SPECIFICATIONS

STYLE: In-ear (Earbud) | CONNECTOR: USB-C | PLATFORM: PC, MAC, Mobile device, Nintendo Switch | DRIVER DIAMETER: 10.8 mm | MICROPHONE: Omni-directional | IMPEDANCE: 16 Ohm | FREQUENCY RESPONSE (HEADPHONES): 20 - 40000 Hz | FREQUENCY RESPONSE (MICROPHONE): 50 - 10000 Hz | NOISE CANCELLATION: ANC | SENSITIVITY: -40 dB ± 3 dB | CABLE LENGTH: 1.25 meter | WEIGHT: 26 g

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